12.8.2 The span_first query

Suppose we want to find a particular word in the first *n* number of tokens. For example, we want to know if *Aristotle* exists in the first five positions of our documents (see figure 12.9).

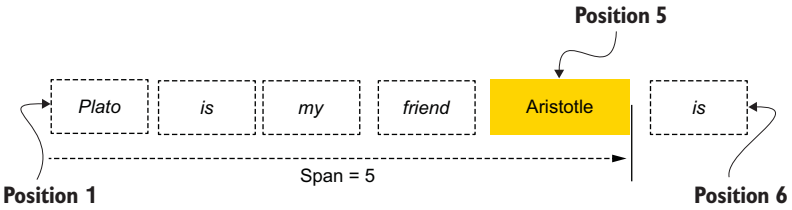


Figure 12.9 Searching for a document with a term in the first *n* number of tokens

As you can deduce from the figure, Aristotle is in the fifth position and therefore exists in the first five positions. This sort of use case can be satisfied by the `span_first` query. We see the query in action in the following listing.

Listing 12.15 Searching for the given term in the first five positions

```
GET quotes/_search
{
  "query": {
    "span_first": {
      "match": {
        "span_term": {
          "quote": "aristotle"
        }
      },
      "end": 5
    }
  }
}
```

Fetches the document in the first n number of spans

The term we want to search for

The first of n positions to find a match

The `span_first` query expects a `match` query where we provide other `span` queries. Here, the `span_term` query is wrapped in a `span_first` query. Although the `span_term` query is equivalent to a `term` query, it is commonly wrapped in other `span` query blocks. The `end` attribute indicates the maximum number of positions permitted when searching for the match term from the beginning of the field (in this case, `end` is `5`).

> **NOTE** The `end` attribute's name is a bit confusing. It is the end position of the token allowed when searching for match terms. I think the name `n_position_from_beginning` would be better suited.

In listing 12.15, we search for *Aristotle* in the first five positions from the start of the quote (see figure 12.9). Because *Aristotle*'s position is fifth, the document consisting of